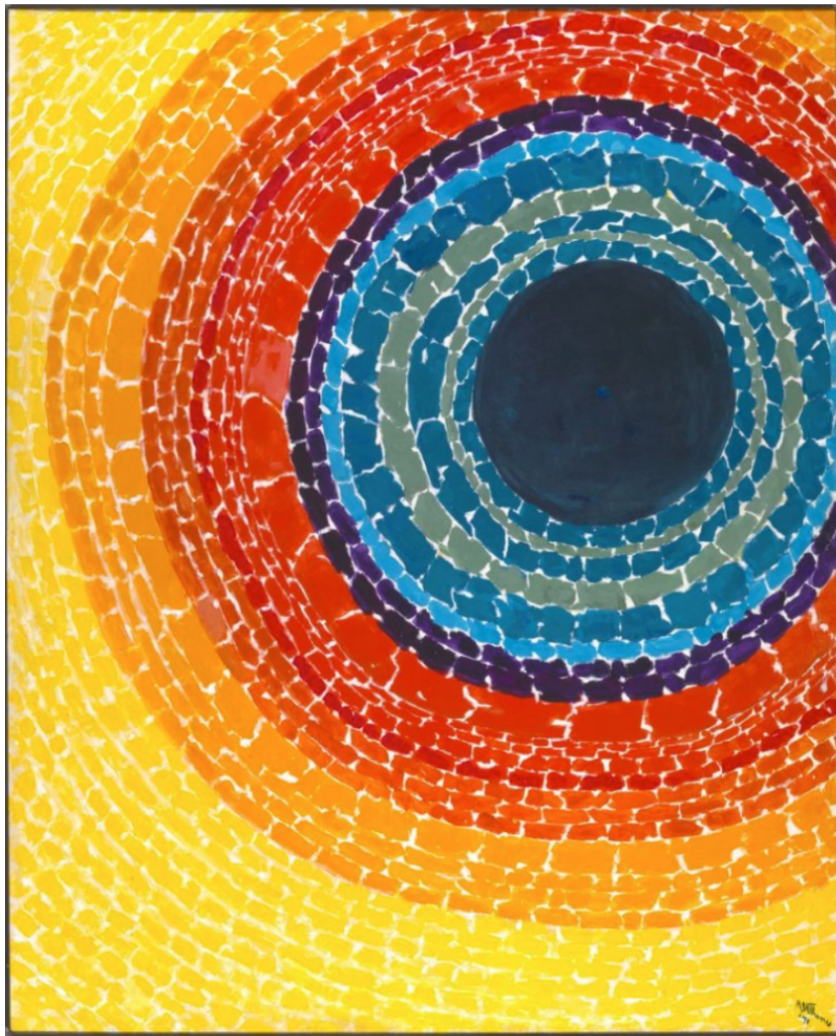


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Turning Over Tables:
A Lenten Call for Disrupting Power
Lament – Lent 2*

March 16th, 2025



The Eclipse, Alma Thomas

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on BEACH SPRING and KINGSFOLD

Requiem - Selections (Gabriel Fauré, adapted for Organ by C. Bull)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Yulia Fox

The Holy meets us in difficult places:
territories of struggle,
feelings of desperation,
and our deepest needs within.

*In our fears and in our pain,
God is beside us.*

We are companioned by the Holy
through the world around us,
through each other,
and through the rhythms of Love Eternal.

Assurance of this Sacred company
enables us to extend
the same care to those around us
so that none of us are left to struggle alone.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Lenten Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering. O God, in Whom All Life Begins**

KINGSFOLD

O God in whom all life begins, who births the seed to fruit,
bestow your blessing on our lives; here let your love find root.
Bring forth in us the Spirit's gifts of patience, joy, and peace;
deliver us from numbing fear, and grant our faith increase.

Unite in mutual ministry our minds and hands and hearts
that we may have the grace to seek the power your peace imparts.
So let our varied gifts combine to glorify your Name
that in all things by word and deed we may your love proclaim.

Through tears and laughter, grief and joy, enlarge our trust and care;
so bind us in community that we may risk and dare.
Be with us when we gather here to worship, sing, and pray,
then send us forth in power and faith to live the words we say.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Hope and fear,
laughter and tears,
have been part of our journey, O God.
Joy and pain,
longing and doubt, meet us on the pathway.
Often we do not believe,
and sometimes we doubt your promises
to be with us and for us can be true.

In the midst of this life,
grant us and our world the freedom to laugh,
the courage to cry,
the heart to be open,
and the faith to believe in you,
and in ourselves.

In this season of Lent, O God,
attune our notice to the needs of others,
and open our hearts,
so that they need not be without comfort.

Let us not be afraid to defend the weak because of the
anger of the strong,
nor afraid to defend the poor because of the
anger of the rich.
Show us where love and hope and faith are needed,
and use us to bring them to those places.

*And then, Holy One, renew and open us with your love,
so that in the days to come,
we will be able to do the work
of peace with you, and with each other.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

ELDER MARTINA SAWT PIERRE

"Female Warrior Protector Chant" from the Lil'Wat Nation
Laude treble voices

***The Lord's Prayer**

Yulia Fox

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

On this Lenten journey,
we lament the absence of peace in our world.
Because we are people who long for peace,
and people who work for peace,
we pray together:

Peace for the earth and its creatures
peace for the world and its peoples
peace for those who do not know peace
peace for those who pray for peace.

The peace of heaven's vastness
the peace of ocean depths
the peace of earth's stillness
to bless all creation this day
to bless all creation this day.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke*
This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Yulia Fox

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Compassionate God,
from our depths new life emerges.
Through our bodies and the bodies of people everywhere,
the creativity of the cosmos is born on earth,
children of eternity are conceived in time,
and everlasting bonds of tenderness and kinship
are forged amidst the hardships of life and its struggles.

In our souls, and in the souls of every living being,
sacred hopes are hidden, longings for that which has never been heard,
and visions for earth's peace, and all that may yet be, are glimpsed.

For those near us and for those far away,
whose lives are in turmoil this day,
and for every place and people in their brokenness,
for the woundedness of our lives,
and for every part of the creation that is suffering,
together, as one people, we ask for a renewed and miraculous awareness
of your loving presence, both this day and in all the days to come.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Still I Rise"

ROSEPHANYE POWELL, WORDS & MUSIC,

INSPIRED BY THE POEM BY MAYA ANGELOU

Cathedral Choir treble voices, Molly Pease, *Soloist*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Conductor*

Sermon

Lement

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"In Remembrance" from *Requiem*

Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Conductor*

ELEANOR DALEY, MUSIC

CHRISTINA ROSSETTI, TEXT

*Lenten Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost. Amen.

***Prayer of Offering**

Yulia Fox

Holy God, as we bring our offerings to you,
we remember all those who are vulnerable to suffering and injustice.
Make us people who are gracious in our giving, tender in our care,
and fierce in our protection of all your beloved people.

May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

For Equilibrium, a Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Lehman

Like the joy of the sea coming home to shore,
May the relief of laughter rinse through your soul.

As the wind loves to call things to dance,
May your gravity be lightened by grace.

Like the dignity of the moonlight restoring the earth,
May your thoughts incline with reverence and respect.

As water takes whatever shape it is in,
So free may you be about who you become.

As silence smiles on the other side of what's said,
May your sense of irony bring perspective.

As time remains free of all that it frames,
May your mind stay clear of all its names.

May your prayer of listening deepen enough
to hear in the depths the tears, and the hopefulness of God.
-John O'Donohue

May it be so!
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Good Morning"

TARA MACK

Laude, Ianthe Marini, *Assistant Director*

***Hymn for the Journey**

The Journey of Faith

BEACH SPRING

To a journey God has called us, to a life of love and hope;
In the light and in the shadow, God is with us as we go.
Faith that grows with each new challenge, trust that leads through paths unknown,
We, as pilgrims, walk together in the journey to our home.

For the strength of faithful witness lived through days of joy and tears;
And the gift of grace sufficient for the ever-flowing years;
For the richness of your mercy to thee, Lord, we give our praise.
May our lives reflect your glory 'till the close of all our days.

Go we now to be God's people, go we now our faith to live.
Help us learn from one another faith to keep, a faith to give.
Go we now on life's great journey, go we now, but not alone.
With God's people, by God's Spirit, faith leads forward, faith leads on.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Libera Me - Paraphrase (Gabriel Fauré, adapted for Organ by C. Bull)

Inside The Music

"Today we sing all music and texts by female composers and poets as we give voice to the theme of *lament*, exploring the ways in which "lament" has been a call to action and an impetus for the work of change for so many women throughout history. We also embrace how spiritual and artistic traditions have made sense of loss through communion with Nature and her healing power. We begin with an invocation of spirit from the Lil'Wat Nation: the *Female Protector Warrior Chant* by Elder Martina Sawt Pierre in her personal response to the epidemic of Missing and Murdered Indigenous Women. Across the United States and Canada, Indigenous women and girls are disproportionately affected by homicide and kidnapping at a rate that is ten times higher than the national average, with murder as the third leading cause of death for First Nations women. In this chant, we hear a crucial plea for action, and a simple and guttural cry of urgency, love, and intention. Elder Sawt Pierre describes the Native belief that the spiritual and physical worlds are connected, and that this chant calls upon the help of the ancestors to bring the women and girls of the community to safety and healing. Our meditation anthem is Dr. Rosephanye Powell's *Still I Rise*, music and lyrics from which she drew inspiration from Maya Angelou's poem of the same name. In her music and words, Powell celebrates the extraordinary resilience of women with a driving beat, uplifting tempo, soaring melody, and tight choral harmonies signifying that indeed, we are stronger together. She implores us to understand that *though you see me slump with heartache; heart so heavy that it breaks, be not deceived I fly on birds' wings, rising sun its healing rays. Look at me, you see a woman, gentle as a butterfly, but don't you think, not for one moment, that I'm not strong because I cry. Yes! Still I rise!* At offertory, we sing Eleanor Daley's setting of the Christina Rossetti poem *In Remembrance*, acknowledging the life eternal of those we have loved and lost who remain present in the *diamond glint on snow, the sunlight on ripened grain, the gentle morning rain, the sweet uplifting rush of quiet birds in circled flight, the soft stars that fall at night*. And finally, we respond in choral benediction with Tara Mack's *Good Morning*, a setting of the traditional nursery rhyme that affirms that the sunshine never goes to sleep, but visits and shares light with all the children around the globe each day: *I never go to sleep, my dear, I just go round to see the little children of the East who rise and watch for me*. In her performance notes, Tara Mack writes that the piece should remind us of *that moment when we believed it was possible to have a conversation with the sun*. In our words and music this morning, we find strength, resilience, beauty, protest, calm, joy, catharsis, and the invocation of ancestral help as we allow our voices to rise together in the uplifting art shared with us by women." -Dr. Ianthe Marini